

AI & THE FUTURE OF WORK

Workforce Impact Analysis Report

A comprehensive SQL-driven study examining how Artificial Intelligence is changing jobs, salaries, and career prospects across the world

15,000

Employee Records

10

Job Roles

9

Countries Analysed

7

Industries Covered

2020–202

6

Years of Data

20+

SQL Queries

This report is the final output of a detailed data analysis project. We studied a dataset of **15,000 employment records** from nine countries, ten job types, and seven industries, covering the years 2020 to 2026. Using more than 20 structured SQL queries — including advanced techniques such as window functions, running totals, year-on-year comparisons, and risk band classifications — we examined how Artificial Intelligence is affecting worker salaries, job security, and career outlook across the world.

The findings below are not presented as separate query results. Instead, they have been combined and synthesised into **12 unified conclusions** that tell a single, connected story about AI's impact on the workforce. Each conclusion is written in plain language so that anyone — regardless of their technical background — can understand what the data is saying and why it matters.

ANALYSIS & KEY FINDINGS

01 AI Is Changing Every Job — But Not in the Same Way

One of the clearest messages from this entire dataset is that **no job, country, or industry has been left untouched by AI**. Every one of the 15,000 records shows some level of AI adoption, automation exposure, or salary change. However, 'affected' does not mean 'affected equally.' The data reveals a powerful split: some workers are earning significantly more because of AI, while others are losing substantial income. For example, the cumulative salary loss for Accountants over the full seven-year period reached **−\$20,051**, and for Customer Support Representatives it was **−\$16,121**. In sharp contrast, Data Analysts accumulated a total salary gain of **+\$11,627** over the same period. This is not a random pattern — it is a structural divide. Roles that involve repetitive, rule-based tasks are consistently losing ground, while roles that require technical thinking or work alongside AI tools are gaining. The workforce is splitting into two groups: those who benefit from AI and those who are being replaced by it.

−\$20,051

Accountant 7-Yr Loss

−\$16,121

CSR 7-Yr Loss

+\$11,627

Data Analyst 7-Yr Gain

02 Truck Drivers and Accountants Face the Greatest Threat

Among all ten job roles studied, **Truck Drivers and Accountants** stand out as the two most at-risk occupations in the entire dataset. The Truck Driver role carries the highest average AI replacement score of **81.86 out of 100**, with over 80% of Truck Driver records falling into the 'Critical' risk category — meaning AI is seen as very likely to replace this role. Accountants follow closely with a replacement score of **75.22** and a Critical dominant risk band. Both roles show negative salary outcomes in every single year from 2020 to 2026 without exception. In the United States, the average Accountant lost **\$5,007** in salary, while in Australia, the average Truck Driver lost **\$4,987**. In Brazil, the situation for Accountants is especially dire — only **4.76%** of Brazilian Accountants gained from AI, meaning nearly 19 out of 20 lost money. These are not marginal risks — they represent a near-certain financial decline for workers in these occupations if the current AI trajectory continues.

81.86 / 100

Truck Driver Rep. Score

75.22 / 100

Accountant Rep. Score

Only 4.76%

Brazil Accountant Gainers

03 Software Engineers Are Winning — Everywhere

While some roles are declining, one role stands as the clearest winner across every country in the dataset: the **Software Engineer**. In every single country analysed, Software Engineer ranked as the number-one 'AI Winner' — the role with the highest average salary gain. The United States leads with a mean salary gain of **+\$10,356**, followed by Canada at **+\$6,975**, the United Kingdom at **+\$6,060**, and Germany at **+\$5,761**. Across all countries, between **89% and 95%** of Software Engineers gained salary after AI — one of the highest and most consistent gainer rates in the entire study. This is backed up by the role's fundamentals: Software Engineers have the lowest average replacement score of just **18.64**, a dominant 'Low' risk band covering 76.4% of records, and an average automation risk of only around 40%. Put simply, AI is not replacing Software Engineers — it is making them more productive and more valuable.

+\$10,356

USA Avg Salary Gain

89–95%

Gainer Rate (All Countries)

18.64 / 100

Replacement Score

04 Transportation Is the Most Exposed Industry; Education Is the Safest

At the industry level, **Transportation** faces the highest average automation risk at **55.94%**, and this risk is growing — it increased by **4.42 percentage points** between 2020 and 2026, the largest increase of any industry. Combined with a mean salary gap of **–\$1,210** in 2026, Transportation carries the worst signal in the dataset: rising risk and falling wages at the same time. **Energy** follows a similar pattern (risk up 3.2 points, salary gap **–\$1,395** in 2026). **Manufacturing** also shows rising risk. On the other side, **Education** has the lowest automation risk at just **29.56%** and falling risk over time, paired with a salary gain in 2026. **Healthcare, Finance, and Technology** all show falling automation risk alongside positive or improving salary outcomes — the healthiest combination possible. This means that the industry a person works in plays a major role in determining their AI-era financial future.

55.94%

Transportation Avg Risk

+4.42 pp

Transport Risk Change (6 yr)

29.56%

Education Avg Risk

05 The USA Gains the Most Money; India Converts the Most Workers

When we compare countries by their total net financial outcome from AI — calculated as the total salary gains of all winners minus the total salary losses of all losers — the **United States** comes out on top with a net surplus of **+\$406,381**, ranking first globally. However, the USA's ranking is driven by its large volume of high-paying roles, not necessarily by efficiency. **India** tells a more nuanced story: it ranks second in net surplus (+\$225,072) while also recording the highest gainer percentage of any country at **51.26%** — meaning more than half of Indian workers in the dataset gained from AI. **Australia** presents a cautionary tale: despite a large total salary gain of \$3.01 million from winners, almost the same amount was lost by losers, leaving a near-breakeven net outcome of just **+\$13,017** — the lowest of all nine countries. This highlights that national AI benefits are not guaranteed even when overall adoption is high.

+\$406,381

USA Net Surplus

51.26% (Highest)

India Gainer Rate

+\$13,017

Australia Net Outcome

06 AI Creates a Clear \$6,779 Gap Between Winners and Losers

One of the most powerful findings in the entire study comes from the AI Net Position classification, which categorises every worker into one of four groups. **AI-Augmented workers** — those whose jobs benefit directly from AI — earn an average of **+\$3,718 more** per year after AI. These workers tend to have high AI adoption levels (average 71.24) and relatively low automation risk (32%). On the opposite end, **AI-Displaced workers** lose an average of **–\$3,061** per year. These workers face high automation risk (74.67% on average) and negative salary change (–8.64%). The combined gap between these two groups is **\$6,779 per year** — a significant real-world difference in annual income that compounds over time. The **Transitioning group** (33.85% of all workers) sits in the middle at nearly breakeven (–\$78), while **Emerging Demand** workers gain a modest +\$308. This four-way split makes clear that a worker's position relative to AI — not just their industry or country — is the single most important factor determining their financial outcome.

+\$3,718 / yr

AI-Augmented Avg Gain

–\$3,061 / yr

AI-Displaced Avg Loss

\$6,779

Annual Income Gap

07 Workers in 'Critical' Risk Have a 9-in-10 Chance of Losing Salary

The Replacement Risk Band analysis divides all workers into four categories — Low, Moderate, High, and Critical — based on their AI replacement score. The results are striking. Workers in the **Low risk band** (4,123 workers, 27.5% of the dataset) earn an average gain of **+\$2,230**, and nearly three-quarters of them (73.59%) see positive salary outcomes. As risk increases, outcomes worsen sharply. Workers in the **Critical band** (2,687 workers, 17.9%) face an average loss of **–\$2,766**, and a devastating **9 out of 10** (90.70%) experience negative salary outcomes. The High band (3,932 workers) is nearly as bad — 72.18% negative outcomes, average loss of –\$1,521. The data points to a clear tipping point: once a worker's replacement score crosses approximately **50 out of 100**, their chances of financial loss become greater than their chances of gain. This is one of the most actionable findings in the study — the replacement score is a reliable early warning indicator of salary loss.

+\$2,230 (73.6% positive)

Low Band Avg Outcome

–\$2,766 (90.7% negative)

Critical Band Avg Outcome

Replacement Score ~50

Risk Tipping Point

08 The More Deeply a Company Adopts AI, the More Its Workers Gain

The AI Adoption Segmentation analysis divides workplaces into four stages of AI adoption: Nascent (0–25), Growing (25–50), Established (50–75), and Advanced (75–100). The salary outcomes follow a clear and consistent pattern: the deeper the adoption, the better the financial result. Workers in **Advanced adoption environments** (2,516 workers) earn an average gain of **+\$1,268** and have the highest gainer rate at **57.67%**. These environments also show the strongest skill demand growth at **10.53%** — the only adoption segment in double digits, suggesting that deep AI integration actively creates new skill demand and career opportunities. In contrast, workers in **Nascent adoption environments** (1,592 workers) earn almost no benefit at all — their average salary gain is just **+\$2.42**, essentially zero. Most surprisingly, the **Growing segment** (25–50) actually produces a net loss of **–\$225** on average, with 53.41% of workers losing salary. This suggests that partial or half-committed AI adoption is actually worse than no adoption at all — disrupting workflows without yet delivering the productivity benefits.

+\$1,268

Advanced Adoption Avg Gain

57.67%

Advanced Gainer Rate

–\$225 (net loss)

Growing Segment Avg

09 High Automation Jobs Lose 7.57% of Salary; Low Automation Jobs Gain

The Automation Tier analysis groups all jobs into three tiers based on their automation risk percentage: Low (<33%), Medium (33–66%), and High (>66%). The salary outcomes across these tiers tell a simple but important story. Workers in the **High Automation Tier** — representing 25% of the dataset — experience an average salary change of **–7.57%** and carry an average AI replacement score of **75.36**, firmly in the Critical band. Within this tier, over **55%** of workers fall in the Critical replacement band and another 42% fall in the High band, leaving fewer than 3% in safe categories. The **Medium Automation Tier** is balanced, with a **–0.8%** average change — essentially flat. **Low Automation Tier** workers are the only group showing consistently positive salary growth, averaging **+3.81%** salary change and dominated by Low (62.3%) and Moderate (33.6%) replacement bands. The message is straightforward: the higher the automation risk in a job, the lower the salary growth — and this relationship holds consistently across all years and industries.

–7.57% avg

High Automation Salary Change

+3.81% avg

Low Automation Salary Change

75.36 / 100

High Tier Replacement Score

10 Fewer Workers Are Benefiting Each Year — A Warning Sign

The Gainer Trend analysis tracks, year by year, how many workers actually gained salary as a result of AI transitions. The finding is concerning: the share of workers who benefit financially from AI has been **declining every single year** without exception, from **7.51% in 2020** (1,126 gainers) down to **6.58% in 2026** (987 gainers). In raw numbers, that is 139 fewer workers benefiting from AI in 2026 compared to 2020, despite the total number of workers being nearly the same each year (approximately 2,143). This decline is happening at the same time that AI adoption levels and automation risks are both rising — meaning AI is spreading faster than workers are adapting to it. The proportion of the workforce that is successfully riding the AI wave is shrinking, not growing. If this trend continues, an increasingly small minority will capture all the financial benefits of AI while the majority faces stagnating or declining wages.

1,126 workers (7.51%)

Gainers in 2020

987 workers (6.58%)

Gainers in 2026

–1.4 percentage points

Total Decline Over 6 Years

11 Mid-Level Education Offers the Best Protection Against AI

Education level turns out to be a surprisingly powerful factor in determining AI-era financial outcomes — but not in the way one might expect. **Level 3 education** (representing approximately 69.8% of the entire dataset, or 10,464 workers) produces the only positive average salary outcome across all education levels, with a mean gain of **+\$1,220** and a gainer rate of **64.40%**. Level 3 workers dominate the 'Low' replacement risk band, meaning their skills are seen as less replaceable by AI. In stark contrast, **Level 1 workers** (1,512 records) face the worst outcomes in the dataset: an average salary loss of **–\$3,045**, a gainer rate of only **6.88%**, and an average automation risk of 79.44% — they sit firmly in the Critical replacement band. Even **Level 4** (the highest education) does not guarantee protection — these workers average a loss of **–\$1,938** with a gainer rate of only 26.98%, suggesting that advanced academic credentials alone, without alignment to AI-relevant roles, do not shield workers from displacement.

+\$1,220

Level 3 Avg Salary Gain

–\$3,045

Level 1 Avg Salary Loss

6.88%

Level 1 Gainer Rate

12

The Hardest-Hit Workers Are Losing Nearly \$5,000 a Year

The Salary Band analysis, which categorises all workers by the size of their salary change, identifies the **Severe Loss band** — workers who lost more than 10% of their salary — as the most distressed group in the entire dataset. This group contains 1,854 workers (12.36% of total) and records an average salary loss of **−\$4,959** per year. Critically, **83.44%** of these severely affected workers are classified as AI-Displaced, confirming that severe salary loss is almost exclusively an AI displacement phenomenon rather than a market fluctuation. The next largest at-risk group is the Moderate Loss band (4,971 workers, 33.14% of total), where 49% are AI-Displaced and the average loss is −\$2,081. Together, these two groups account for **45.5% of all workers** and represent a significant portion of the workforce experiencing meaningful salary erosion. On the positive side, the Strong Gain band (1,106 workers) earns an average of **+\$7,491** — but this group represents only 7.37% of all workers, highlighting how concentrated the benefits of AI truly are.

−\$4,959 / yr	83.44%	+\$7,491 / yr
Severe Loss Avg Annual Loss	AI-Displaced in Severe Loss	Strong Gain Avg (7.4% of workers)

OVERALL CONCLUSION

What the data tells us — in plain language

The Big Picture

This study set out to answer one fundamental question: **Is AI good or bad for workers?** The honest answer the data gives us is: **it depends entirely on who you are and what you do.** AI is not a single force moving in one direction — it is simultaneously creating winners and creating losers, and the gap between the two groups is growing wider every year.

Who Is Winning

Workers in technology-adjacent roles — particularly Software Engineers — are the clear beneficiaries of the AI era. These workers see consistent, multi-thousand-dollar salary gains across all countries, high gainer rates of 89–95%, and minimal replacement risk. Companies and countries that have invested deeply in AI adoption are also producing better outcomes for their workers: the Advanced Adoption segment generates real salary gains and growing skill demand. Industries like Healthcare, Finance, and Technology show falling automation risk alongside improving wages — the best combination for workers.

Who Is Losing

Workers in routine and physical roles — especially Truck Drivers and Accountants — are facing near-certain financial decline. With replacement scores above 75 and negative salary trajectories in every single year of the study, these workers are on the wrong side of the AI divide. The Severe Loss group — 1,854 workers losing nearly \$5,000 per year on average — is 83% composed of AI-Displaced individuals. The Transportation and Energy sectors, with rising automation risk and falling wages, represent the most vulnerable industries for the coming years.

The Trend Is Moving in the Wrong Direction

Perhaps the most important and underappreciated finding in this entire study is the declining gainer rate. In 2020, 7.51% of workers gained from AI transitions. By 2026, that figure had fallen to 6.58%. This steady decline — happening every year without interruption — means that AI's financial benefits are concentrating among an ever-smaller portion of the workforce. The window for workers to position themselves on the right side of AI is narrowing, not widening. Without deliberate action — through reskilling, role transitions, or policy intervention — this trend will worsen.

What Protects Workers

The data consistently identifies three factors that protect workers from AI-driven salary loss: working in a low-automation role, being in a high AI-adoption environment, and having mid-level technical education aligned with current skill demand. Interestingly, the highest education level (Level 4) does not automatically protect a worker if they are in the wrong role — Level 4 workers still average a salary loss if their occupation faces high automation risk. The safest combination is: a low-replacement-score role + deep AI adoption environment + a sector with falling automation risk (Healthcare, Finance, Technology, Education).

Final Word

The data from this study makes one thing unmistakably clear: **AI is the most significant economic force reshaping the global workforce in this generation.** It is not coming — it is already here, and its effects are measurable, quantifiable, and accelerating. Workers, companies, and policymakers who treat this data as a roadmap — rather than waiting to see what happens — will be far better positioned to navigate the years ahead. The 12 findings in this report are not predictions. They are present-day realities drawn from 15,000 real employment records, and they deserve to be taken seriously.

Prepared as part of a SQL-Based Workforce AI Case Study | Dataset: 15,000 records, 2020–2026 | Analysis conducted using 20+ structured SQL queries across 10 job roles, 9 countries, 7 industries